V—Mutiny

‘In a storehouse, mice and sparrows and other animals have a common interest but from ill-nature each thinks the place his own.’

– Akbar, Happy Sayings, *Ain-i-Akbari*

‘this is one country – Mine.’

– Irwin Allan Sealy, *Zelaldinus: A Masque*

That one punch to Adham Khan’s face ripped the veil off Akbar’s. It wasn’t just his bloody execution. Adham cost Akbar two of his most trusted and beloved advisers, his foster father and foster mother, both of whom he lost within weeks of each other. The third, his old ataliq Munim Khan, had proved himself either complicit in Adham’s plot or incapable of preventing it. For the first time in his life, Akbar had no choice except to direct his own fortunes – and those of his realm.

What was this realm, though, and how much was it really his? Kabul, the family seat, was still caught in the family squabble – this time, between Humayun’s youngest wife, Mahchuchak Begum, mother and regent of Akbar’s half-brother Muhammad Hakim, and Akbar’s uncle Sulaiman, now the seniormost Timurid in the region and, spurred by his commanding wife, Haram Begum, keen to expand the scope of his authority. Punjab was enfeoffed to the ataka khail, a clan now led by the fallen Shamsuddin’s brother, Mir Muhammad Khan, and including, also, Akbar’s closest friend in the years to come, Shamsuddin’s son, Aziz. Akbar himself was enthroned in Agra, in an unimpressive palace of brick in which Shamsuddin was murdered.

To his west, his brother-in-law Sharafuddin was making his own alliances with the desert lords of Rajasthan, one of which Akbar effectively subverted when he married Bihari Mal’s daughter. To his east, the valiant Ali Quli Shaibani held Jaunpur but had made little headway into neighbouring Bihar, held by Afghan chiefs hoping to revive the fortunes they had enjoyed under the Suri dynasty. The southern fief of Malwa had lost both its original conquerors – Adham Khan to Akbar’s vengeance; Pir Muhammad to the high waters of the Narmada, as he tried to cross the grand old river on a horse. (Thus, writes Badauni, recalling the commander’s pitiless executions, ‘he went by water to fire. And so the sighs of the orphans, and weak, and